Seminar case: Large Language Models in Higher Education: AI, assessment and academic integrity

CS5805 Ethics and Governance of Digital Systems · Lecture 3 seminar · 60 minutes

Before the seminar: read this case, Cotton, Cotton and Shipway (2024) and Liang et al. (2023).

A note on this case: it is about you. Most of you use AI tools, and your work is assessed under university AI policies. Use your own experience, but you do not have to share anything personal.

The case

1. Almost everyone is using it

ChatGPT was released in November 2022. Within three years, AI use among UK students had become almost universal. A survey of 1,054 UK undergraduates in December 2025 found that 95% use AI in some way, and 94% use generative AI to help with assessed work (HEPI, 2026).

The share who say they paste AI-generated text directly into assessed work has risen from 3% in 2024 to 8% in 2025 and 12% in 2026. Fewer than half (48%) feel their teaching staff help them develop AI skills, and only 37% say their institution encourages AI use. Some students report anxiety about being falsely accused of misconduct.

2. Universities respond

In July 2023, the 24 Russell Group universities agreed five principles. They committed to make students and staff AI-literate, to adapt teaching and assessment to include ethical AI use, to support equal access, and to uphold academic rigour and integrity.

At the same time, many universities turned to software that claims to detect AI-written text. Turnitin added an AI-writing indicator to its plagiarism checker in 2023. Turnitin itself says the score "should not be used as the sole basis for adverse actions against a student".

The numbers suggest a growing problem. A Guardian investigation using Freedom of Information requests to 131 UK universities found almost 7,000 proven cases of AI-assisted cheating in 2023 – 24. That is 5.1 per 1,000 students, up from 1.6 the year before. Yet detection is unreliable in both directions. In a blind test at the University of Reading, AI-written exam answers went undetected 94% of the time and, on average, scored higher than real students' work (Scarfe et al., 2024).

3. When the machine is the accuser

In May 2023, a lecturer at Texas A&M University – Commerce pasted his students' final essays into ChatGPT and asked whether it had written them. ChatGPT said yes, for many of them. The lecturer gave the affected students an incomplete grade, and some feared they would not graduate.

ChatGPT cannot reliably tell whether it wrote a piece of text. One student cleared their name using the time-stamped edit history in Google Docs. The university later confirmed that no students failed the class or were barred from graduating.

4. Six thousand cases

In 2024, Australian Catholic University (ACU) recorded nearly 6,000 alleged academic misconduct cases. About 90% involved suspected AI use. Many referrals relied on Turnitin's AI detector.

An ABC News investigation, published in October 2025, described what accused students went through. They were asked to provide handwritten and typed notes, sometimes dozens of pages long, and in some cases their full internet search histories, to prove they had not used AI.

One final-year nursing student, Madeleine, waited six months for her case to be dropped. During that time her transcript showed "results withheld", and she believes this cost her a graduate job offer. A paramedic student's essay was flagged as 84% AI-written. Facing the cost of repeating a unit, the student felt there was no option but to comply.

ACU's deputy vice-chancellor said the reported figures were "substantially overstated". She said about a quarter of referrals were dismissed after investigation, and any case based only on the detector was dismissed immediately. She acknowledged investigations were not always as timely as they should have been. ACU had known of problems with the tool for over a year, and stopped using it in March 2025.

5. Who gets flagged?

In 2023, Stanford researchers ran 91 essays written by non-native English speakers for the TOEFL exam through seven AI detectors. On average, the detectors labelled 61% of these human-written essays as AI-generated, and all seven agreed on 19% of them. The same detectors were near-perfect on essays by US-born eighth-graders (Liang et al., 2023).

The reason is that detectors look for predictable, simple wording. Writers with a smaller English vocabulary are therefore more likely to be flagged, even when every word is their own.

6. The decision

A UK university is reviewing its approach for next year. It has three broad options, which can be combined:

- Detect and enforce**:** keep using AI-detection software to flag suspected misuse for investigation.
- Redesign assessment: reduce reliance on detection by changing how students are assessed, for example with in-person elements, vivas, or tasks that permit and require disclosure of AI use.
- Educate and disclose: teach AI literacy and require students to declare how they used AI, treating undeclared use as the integrity issue.

Whatever it chooses, uploading student work to third-party tools involves processing personal data. Under UK data protection law, students also have rights where significant decisions about them are made solely by automated means.

Questions

Answer all six questions. Use the ethical perspectives and Moral Foundations Theory from Lectures 2 and 3, and support your arguments with evidence from the case and the reading.

1. Identify three stakeholders affected by the use of AI detection in university assessment. For each, explain one ethical concern the case raises for them.
2. Using a utilitarian perspective, evaluate whether universities should use AI-detection scores as evidence of misconduct. Consider both false positives (honest students flagged) and false negatives (AI use missed).
3. ACU asked accused students to provide their notes and internet search histories to prove their innocence. Using deontological or rights-based reasoning, evaluate whether this was a fair way to treat students.
4. Liang et al. (2023) found that detectors disproportionately flag non-native English writers. Using Moral Foundations Theory, analyse why staff and students might judge AI use and its detection so differently. Refer to at least two moral foundations.
5. Evaluate how far current governance — institutional policy, the Russell Group principles, and UK data protection law — protects students from the harms in this case. Where are the gaps?
6. Recommend three governance measures for a UK university's approach to generative AI in assessment. Justify each using an ethical perspective and the reading, and state whether your overall stance is universalist or relativist.

Reading

- Cotton, D.R.E., Cotton, P.A. and Shipway, J.R. (2024) Chatting and cheating: ensuring academic integrity in the era of ChatGPT. *Innovations in Education and Teaching International*, 61(2), 228–239. Open access: Plymouth Marjon repository
- Liang, W., Yuksekgonul, M., Mao, Y., Wu, E. and Zou, J. (2023) GPT detectors are biased against non-native English writers. *Patterns*, 4(7), 100779.
- Adel, A., Ahsan, A. and Davison, C. (2024) ChatGPT promises and challenges in education: computational and ethical perspectives. *Education Sciences*, 14(8), 814. Sections 5 and 7. While reading, look closely at p. 4. What does it tell you about how the paper was written?
- Optional: Perkins, M., Furze, L., Roe, J. and MacVaugh, J. (2024) The Artificial Intelligence Assessment Scale (AIAS). *Journal of University Teaching and Learning Practice*, 21(6).

Case sources

- HEPI (12 March 2026) Student Generative AI Survey 2026
- Russell Group (4 July 2023) New principles on use of AI in education
- eWeek (17 June 2025), reporting the Guardian's FOI investigation into AI cheating at UK universities
- University of Reading (27 June 2024) AI-generated exam answers go undetected in real-world blind test

- Ubergizmo (19 May 2023) on the Texas A&M – Commerce incident
- Futurism, reporting the ABC News (9 October 2025) investigation into Australian Catholic University
- Stanford HAI (15 May 2023) AI detectors biased against non-native English writers